



to get these things right from the start. The next step is to think about the energy it takes to make your product or offer your service. Most businesses use fuel and water. Is there a way to reduce consumption, for instance, by using electric vehicles or working from well-insulated premises? The third is to think about the further effects of the product after purchase. What type of packaging was used? Is the item made from recycled materials or can it be recycled? Perhaps the packaging can be returned by the customer for a refill, which is also a good way of ensuring that the customer comes back.

Finally, a word of caution. Sustainability credentials can help promote a business and build a reputation, but it is important to keep checking that the venture stays environmentally friendly. A good name can be lost if people discover that claims are not genuine.

#### MUTUAL BENEFITS

***When a new business draws on local resources, everyone benefits from its success.***

- **The new restaurant** with a menu using local produce served by local staff creates its own community identity.
- **The furniture restorer** who transforms old furniture into fashionable new pieces helps reduce waste.
- **The company** that turns scrap cars and vans into fully electric vehicles benefits the local community and supports the global move to cleaner fuels.

#### HELP SOLVE THE PLASTIC PROBLEM

While ecologists warn that our oceans are polluted with plastic waste, entrepreneurs are finding new ways to recycle plastic into desirable products. Some create fabrics from plastic waste, while others transform it into furniture, bricks, clocks, and fuels, or add it to asphalt to strengthen road surfaces. If you are going to use plastics in your product make sure they are recyclable (see pp212-215).

**“Sustainable development is the pathway to the future we want for all.”**

Ban Ki-moon, Secretary-General of the UN (2007-2016)

